



Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading

2025 Released Test Items

Sports Are Great Because They're Pointless

by Arthur C. Brooks

- 1 Even though I've never lived in Chicago, I have a soft spot for the Cubs. My father grew up in the Windy City and loved the team his whole life. And I loved my dad. So, by the transitive property,¹ I loved the Cubs too. Two decades after my father's death, I am still a fan. Every time I watch the Cubs on television, I think of him and have a conversation with him in my head about the game.
- 2 Perhaps baseball strikes you as too trivial a thing for father and son to connect over. Maybe we could have bonded more through our shared vocation (I am an academic, like he was—and like his father was too), or our feelings toward our relatives. Compared with family and career concerns, a ball game might seem, frankly, sort of useless.
- 3 But that is precisely what makes it ideal for forming relationships. In a transactional world, our relationships with others tend to become part of a web of useful alliances. But such alliances make for the least satisfying relationships. If you are finding that your closest bonds of friendship and family leave you feeling empty, the solution is not to make your relationships more practical. It is to organize them more around things that aren't useful at all—like baseball.
- 4 When it comes to understanding our relationships with others, for my money, the best source is Aristotle. He wrote extensively about the many types of *philia*, or the mutual attraction and attachment that form the basis of every relationship between human beings. *Philia* based on transaction is the least virtuous kind, according to Aristotle. For example, I am friendly with my dentist, and she is friendly with me, which makes it less unpleasant for me to give her hundreds of dollars to drill my teeth. At the other end of the spectrum is *philia* based simply on the deep satisfaction that a relationship brings to each person in it, and a desire that the other be happy. They "wish each alike the other's good," Aristotle wrote.
- 5 This highest *philia* often includes a common love for a third thing, such as religious faith or a search for moral perfection. I have one close friendship, for example, in which my friend and I frequently discuss our efforts at improving ourselves as people. But as research has shown in the more than 2,400 years since Aristotle described *philia*, a mutual love doesn't have to be for something profound in order for it to bolster a deep friendship. Just as the highest *philia* is not "useful" in a worldly sense, the love that sustains it can be for something that might seem trivial. The point is that it brings friends together in shared satisfaction, without being transactional.

¹ transitive property: the concept that if A=B and B=C, then A=C

- 6 And this brings me back to the Cubs, the team that brought me together with my dad We had nothing to gain as we watched them play, except for the satisfaction of enjoying the games together as father and son, a satisfaction that was much greater than it would have been had either of us watched without the other. The Cubs were the “place” where we met to enjoy our bond.
- 7 Lots of sports fans have similar experiences. In their forthcoming book, *Fans Have More Friends*, the sportswriters Ben Valenta and David Sikorjak find that the biggest enthusiasts have the best social lives. The authors measured the intensity of one’s love for sports—they call it “fandom”—by people’s self-rated passion as well as the time they spend watching and participating; they then compared that with the quality of people’s friendships and family life. The relationships are correlative² but striking. For example, 42 percent of the most involved sports fans were “very satisfied” with their family life, compared with less than a quarter of nonfans. Sixty-one percent of fans, but only 37 percent of nonfans, said they “felt close to people.”
- 8 These findings are consistent with past research on sports fans. Scholars have found that both fandom and fan loyalty are positively associated with a sense of belonging and a sense of meaning. One study from last year showed that active sports participation actually *causes* greater life satisfaction. And in a 2009 study of 900 people who played sports in the Netherlands, a third said that they “generated their social networks, their self-esteem and trust in others primarily through sport.” Sports are just one example; research shows that people bond in meaningful ways over all kinds of impractical things, from classic cars to birdhouses to cheesy TV.
- 9 If your relationships with friends and family are leaving you a little cold, you might be suffering from excessive usefulness in your activities. Maybe the solution is cultivating a taste for baseball, or maybe instead for opera, chess, or *Jeopardy*. No matter what your friendship-boosting hobby is, be sure to follow two rules.

1) Make it intrinsic, not instrumental.

- 10 Remember that Aristotle’s perfect *philia* requires you to focus on the inherent satisfaction you get from someone’s company, not worldly gains such as money or career advancement. Your pastime should mostly serve that satisfaction goal. . . .

2) The point is *philia*, not passion.

- 11 If I am to be truthful with you, I am not authentically passionate about any pastimes, and I never have been. I envy people who honestly seem to *love* college football, whittling, or singing in a

² correlative: connected, corresponding

community choir, because I am not one of them. That doesn't stop me from achieving perfect *philia*, however. You can still form a bond with someone you appreciate by dabbling in something you like but don't love. To cultivate better *philia*, don't pretend to enjoy something you really hate. But do consider what your loved ones enjoy, and if those interests appeal to you at all, you can adopt them by choice.

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- 1.** How do paragraphs 10–11 add meaning to the passage?
- Ⓐ by examining how one person can share a hobby with a larger group
 - Ⓑ by giving advice about incorporating common interests into relationships
 - Ⓒ by emphasizing how some hobbies promote friendships more than others
 - Ⓓ by highlighting how theories about attachment continue to change over time

- 2.** How does the title of the passage relate to the author’s overall point?
- Ⓐ by introducing a unique perspective on a common topic
 - Ⓑ by demonstrating how specific activities should be organized
 - Ⓒ by giving an example of how to make interests more purposeful
 - Ⓓ by expressing the frustration that can develop in some situations

- 3.** How does the story of his father in paragraph 1 contribute to the author's purpose?
- Ⓐ It uses a logical appeal to explain his doubts about why he continues to enjoy baseball.
 - Ⓑ It uses a logical appeal to demonstrate why his father wanted to teach him how to play sports.
 - Ⓒ It uses an emotional appeal to connect his love for his father to his support for a specific sports team.
 - Ⓓ It uses an emotional appeal to describe why his childhood memories of baseball are hard for him to remember.

- 4.** Read this sentence from the passage.

“In a transactional world, our relationships with others tend to become part of a web of useful alliances.” (paragraph 3)

How does the figurative language in this sentence support the author’s advice about relationships?

- Ⓐ It reveals why some relationships are long lasting.
- Ⓑ It acknowledges how comfortable some relationships can be.
- Ⓒ It describes relationships that are based on personal benefits.
- Ⓓ It highlights specific differences between types of relationships.

- 5.** Select **two** ways the author supports the claim that relationships based on money struggle to develop *philia* in paragraph 4.
- Ⓐ He uses a personal example.
 - Ⓑ He includes the results of a study.
 - Ⓒ He cites the opinion of a historical figure.
 - Ⓓ He compares amateur athletes with fans.
 - Ⓔ He summarizes the responses from a survey.

6. How does the author use logical reasoning to develop the argument that *philia* can come from a variety of hobbies?
- Ⓐ He explores the particular case of sports to build to a general statement about all hobbies.
 - Ⓑ He starts with a general claim about hobbies and then applies that claim to sports specifically.
 - Ⓒ He focuses on how hobbies affected one relationship and then expands that pattern to his other relationships.
 - Ⓓ He notices how he feels about one hobby and then concludes that hobbies are the best way to improve happiness.

7. Select the detail that helps to explain the meaning of the word trivial.

- 2 Ⓐ Perhaps baseball strikes you as too trivial a thing for
Ⓑ father and son to connect over. Maybe we could have bonded
more through Ⓒ our shared vocation (I am an academic, like he
was—and like his father was too), or our feelings Ⓓ toward our
relatives. Compared with family and career concerns, a ball game
might seem, frankly, Ⓔ sort of useless.

- 8.** Read this sentence from the passage.

“Even though I’ve never lived in Chicago, I have a soft spot for the Cubs.” (paragraph 1)

What does the phrase “a soft spot” suggest?

- Ⓐ a confusing opinion
- Ⓑ an interesting fanbase
- Ⓒ a comfortable location
- Ⓓ an emotional attachment

Passage 1: Why Do People Love Games?

by Sam Von Ehren

- 1 Why do people love games? As the Game Maker for The New York Times, I grapple with this question every day. The reductively easy answer is simple: They're fun! But why are they fun? Do they have to be fun? As we dig deeper and deeper, we find more questions. What even is a game? What is fun? My take on the appeal of games is also simple, if paradoxical. Games are a controlled form of freedom. Our brains grab onto them because they are structures that exist to be avoided.
- 2 Games occupy a strange place in our cultural consciousness. Nearly everyone has played a game at some point in their lives. Despite that ubiquity, games are rarely discussed with the same reverence as other media like films or books. For most, games are like chocolate: a guilty pleasure consumed secretly. The game designer Sid Meier once remarked that "a game is a series of interesting choices." Navigating these choices shapes the course of play, revealing who we are and how we think. Playing a game is an act of exposition. . . .
- 3 Imagine a circle drawn in chalk on a sidewalk. When we are inside the chalk we are "playing" the game. We'll only do what the rules of the game allow. We will try to win. When the game ends, we leave the circle and return to normal. The magic circle is what separates a game from reality.
- 4 I use the metaphor of a chalk line because the magic circle is not an absolute barrier or even a physical one. We can enter and exit the magic circle freely. We bring our bodies, personalities, and life experiences into the game. We take the memories and experience of the game with us when we leave. The chalk line casts a spell on that space of sidewalk and turns it into a space for playing. . . .
- 5 Humans have always been drawn to this trick, finding novel ways to play within their environments. In prehistoric times, humans were playing games with sheep ankle bones called Knucklebones. These oddly shaped bones afforded a game similar to jacks. Players balance a few bones on top of their hands, then toss a few in the air, capturing as many as possible on the way down. Go, a strategy game invented in ancient China, is still played, highlighting part of what is so fascinating about games. Although Go's origin is unclear, many scholars speculate that it was created to teach tactics and strategy. When we enter the magic circle, we give ourselves permission to explore, to fail, to lose. When we stop playing Go, we carry that experience with us. The same is true for Chess, Poker, or any number of analog games.

- 6 Digital games take many of the powers of traditional analog games and ramp up both the rate of interaction and the complexity of the underlying systems. A digital game takes input from the player 60 times per second, resolves it with a potentially very complicated rule set, and renders a new image of the game state. This rapid feedback loop engages our proprioception, that is our sense of embodiment and physicality. Digital games are powerfully compelling as a result, but I often find that analog games are a bit more playful. When playing an analog game, the only limitations are the rules you’ve agreed to, you can modify and change them at will, more easily creating playful experiences.

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Passage 2: Video games level up life skills

by Kathryn Hulick

- 7 When gamers band together to defeat a three-headed zombie dragon boss, they may not be thinking much about school or work. Still, they are likely building skills that will come in handy in the real world, a new study finds. Researchers in Scotland found that playing video games in a group can improve young adults’ communication skills and resourcefulness. It also can make them better at *adapting* to new situations.
- 8 Sharpening those skills can help someone get a job or advance in a career. “Employers want you to think for yourself and adapt to changing situations,” says Matthew Barr, who conducted the new study. He studies video games and gamer culture at the University of Glasgow in Scotland. He also played a lot of video games while growing up.
- 9 From his own experience, Barr knows that video games demand quick thinking. “Games are always keeping you on your toes. You have to be able to figure out what to do if you’re just dropped into a situation,” he says. Multiplayer games also require good communication among players.
- 10 Barr wanted to know whether these gaming skills carry over into real life. So he recruited 16 university students to play eight different video games. The students played in a computer lab over an eight-week period. They could come and go whenever they wanted to, but each had to play for a total of 14 hours.

- 11 Another group of students did not play any games at the lab. This was the *control group*. To understand the effect of a change in behavior, scientists must compare at least two groups. One or more groups will change their behavior. The control group, in contrast, makes no changes.
- 12 The games covered a variety of genres. . . . Six of the games in the study included ways for players to work together in the game itself. Two of the games were single-player only. But the students talked through these games as they played. So all of the games prompted conversation and cooperation.
- 13 Both before and after the study, students in both groups filled out three questionnaires about their real-life skills. One measured their communication skills, such as talking and listening. Another measured adaptability. This investigated how well people deal with changing situations. The third questionnaire looked at resourcefulness. This includes problem-solving and knowing when to ask for help. . . .
- 14 Barr found that after two months of playing video games regularly, students' scores on all three skills improved. Resourcefulness scores increased significantly for 81 percent of the gamers. Adaptability scores increased for 75 percent. And communication skills scores increased for 69 percent of gamers.
- 15 In contrast, fewer than half of the students in the control group improved their scores in each of the three areas.
- 16 Barr's results appear in the October issue of *Computers & Education*.

Part of the team

- 17 Barr also interviewed the study participants about the experience. Several students told him that playing games on a team helped to not only break down their anxieties but also to build their confidence. In that sense, he believes sports and video games may build similar life skills. "It's kind of like joining the hockey team," he says.
- 18 Barr thinks schools should have video games as extracurricular activities—just like sports. A school could set up a video game room, for example, or start a gaming club on campus.
- 19 Beverley Oliver is an expert in education at Deakin University in Melbourne, Australia. She wasn't involved in the study. She isn't convinced that schools should add a video game room. "Playing games develops skills," she says. "This is no surprise." But that's not only true of video games. The game could just as easily be hopscotch or Monopoly, she notes. And there are other ways to sharpen the same life skills that might also improve with gaming. . . .

- 20 Barr points out that other skill-building activities, such as traditional sports, aren't for everybody. Video games may be a more fun or effective way for certain students to gain the same kinds of skills. In his opinion, the study results are a perfect excuse to get your game on.

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9. “As the Game Maker for The New York Times, I grapple with this question every day.” (paragraph 1)

What is the meaning of the phrase grapple with as it is used in this sentence?

- Ⓐ answer
- Ⓑ consider
- Ⓒ repeat
- Ⓓ simplify

10. How does the author of Passage 1 develop his argument about digital versus analog games?

- Ⓐ by describing the limitations of analog games
- Ⓑ by describing the origins and purposes of digital games
- Ⓒ by explaining that digital games are too similar to each other
- Ⓓ by explaining that analog games have fewer and more flexible rules

11. How do paragraphs 3–4 contribute to Passage 1?

- Ⓐ by describing ways that players can change a game to become more engaging
- Ⓑ by explaining elements and benefits of a game that players of the game may not realize
- Ⓒ by describing a simple and common game that can feel magical if played for long enough
- Ⓓ by explaining circumstances in which a game becomes too complicated for average players

12. How does the **Part of the team** section add to the purpose of Passage 2?
Select **two** answers.

- Ⓐ by describing the appeal of playing video games
- Ⓑ by emphasizing that video games involve cooperation
- Ⓒ by suggesting that video games work best with many players
- Ⓓ by explaining how video games were built to model traditional games
- Ⓔ by arguing that kids who enjoy sports will like video games even more

13. How do the rhetorical questions in paragraph 1 of Passage 1 support the author's appeal?

- Ⓐ They encourage the reader to consider why games are popular.
- Ⓑ They share thoughts that fans have submitted regarding games.
- Ⓒ They show that people prefer games with friends over solo games.
- Ⓓ They urge the reader to reconsider what types of games are preferred.

14. Read this sentence from Passage 2.

“Several students told him that playing games on a team helped to not only break down their anxieties but also to build their confidence.”
(paragraph 17)

How do the phrases “break down their anxieties” and “build their confidence” advance the author’s appeal?

- Ⓐ It challenges previous opinions about video games.
- Ⓑ It introduces other powerful life benefits of video games.
- Ⓒ It implies that students prefer studies conducted by professors.
- Ⓓ It emphasizes the types of students who participated in the study.

15. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Select **two** central ideas of Passage 1.

- Ⓐ Games have proven essential for childhood growth.
- Ⓑ Games are an important part of the human experience.
- Ⓒ The definition of a game has changed frequently over time.
- Ⓓ The differences between digital and analog games are vast.
- Ⓔ Games have many forms and are valuable in different ways.

Part B

Which detail from the passage supports the **two** central ideas from Part A?

- Ⓐ “As we dig deeper and deeper, we find more questions.” (paragraph 1)
- Ⓑ “Navigating these choices shapes the course of play, revealing who we are and how we think.” (paragraph 2)
- Ⓒ “Players balance a few bones on top of their hands, then toss a few in the air, capturing as many as possible on the way down.” (paragraph 5)
- Ⓓ “This rapid feedback loop engages our proprioception, that is our sense of embodiment and physicality.” (paragraph 6)

16. Read this sentence from Passage 1.

“Digital games take many of the powers of traditional analog games and ramp up both the rate of interaction and the complexity of the underlying systems.” (paragraph 6)

The word “complexity” comes from a Latin word meaning “connected.” Based on this information, what is the meaning of complexity as it is used in this sentence?

- Ⓐ puzzle
- Ⓑ typical use
- Ⓒ momentum
- Ⓓ advanced level

from *Rip Van Winkle*

by Washington Irving

One night, Rip Van Winkle encountered a strange and unsettling group of men. He observed their party and had some of their drink before falling into a deep sleep. He is now heading back home on what he believes is the next morning.

- 1 As he approached the village, he met a number of people, but none whom he knew, which somewhat surprised him, for he had thought himself acquainted with every one in the country round. Their dress, too, was of a different fashion from that to which he was accustomed. They all stared at him with equal marks of surprise, and whenever they cast their eyes upon him, invariably stroked their chins. The constant recurrence of this gesture induced Rip, involuntarily, to do the same, when, to his astonishment, he found his beard had grown a foot long!
- 2 He had now entered the skirts of the village. A troop of strange children ran at his heels, hooting after him, and pointing at his gray beard. The dogs, too, not one of which he recognized for an old acquaintance, barked at him as he passed. The very village was altered; it was larger and more populous. There were rows of houses which he had never seen before, and those which had been his familiar haunts had disappeared. Strange names were over the doors—strange faces at the windows,—everything was strange. His mind now misgave him; he began to doubt whether both he and the world around him were not bewitched. Surely this was his native village, which he had left but the day before. There stood the Kaatskill Mountains—there ran the silver Hudson at a distance—there was every hill and dale precisely as it had always been—Rip was sorely perplexed. . . .
- 3 The appearance of Rip, with his long grizzled beard, his rusty fowling-piece, his uncouth dress, and an army of women and children at his heels, soon attracted the attention of the tavern-politicians. They crowded round him, eying him from head to foot with great curiosity. The orator bustled up to him, and, drawing him partly aside, inquired “on which side he voted?” . . . Rip was equally at a loss to comprehend the question; when a knowing, self-important old gentleman, in a sharp cocked hat, made his way through the crowd, putting them to the right and left with his elbows as he passed, and planting himself before Van Winkle, with one arm akimbo, the other resting on his cane, his keen eyes and sharp hat penetrating, as it were, into his very soul, demanded in an austere tone, “what brought

him to the election with . . . a mob at his heels, and whether he meant to breed a riot in the village?" — "Alas! gentlemen," cried Rip, somewhat dismayed, "I am a poor quiet man, a native of the place, and a loyal subject of the king, God bless him!"

4 Here a general shout burst from the bystanders—"A tory! a tory! a spy! a refugee! hustle him! away with him!" It was with great difficulty that the self-important man in the cocked hat restored order; and, having assumed a tenfold austerity of brow, demanded again of the unknown culprit what he came there for, and whom he was seeking? The poor man humbly assured him that he meant no harm, but merely came there in search of some of his neighbors, who used to keep about the tavern.

5 "Well—who are they?—name them."

6 Rip bethought himself a moment, and inquired, "Where's Nicholas Vedder?"

7 There was a silence for a little while, when an old man replied, in a thin, piping voice: "Nicholas Vedder? why, he is dead and gone these eighteen years! There was a wooden tombstone in the churchyard that used to tell all about him, but that's rotten and gone too."

8 "Where's Brom Dutcher?"

9 "Oh, he went off to the army in the beginning of the war . . . I don't know—he never came back again."

10 "Where's Van Bummel, the school-master?"

11 "He went off to the wars too, was a great militia general, and is now in Congress."

12 Rip's heart died away, at hearing of these sad changes in his home and friends, and finding himself thus alone in the world. Every answer puzzled him too, by treating of such enormous lapses of time, and of matters which he could not understand: war—Congress; he had no courage to ask after any more friends, but cried out in despair, "Does nobody here know Rip Van Winkle?"

13 "Oh, Rip Van Winkle!" exclaimed two or three, "Oh, to be sure! that's Rip Van Winkle yonder, leaning against the tree."

14 Rip looked, and beheld a precise counterpart of himself, as he went up the mountain: apparently as lazy, and certainly as ragged. The poor fellow was now completely confounded. He doubted his own identity, and whether he was himself or another man. In the midst of his bewilderment, the man in the cocked hat demanded who he was, and what was his name?

15 "God knows," exclaimed he, at his wit's end; "I'm not myself—I'm somebody else—that's me yonder—no—that's somebody else got into my shoes—I was myself last night, but I fell asleep on the mountain, . . .

and everything's changed, and I'm changed, and I can't tell what's my name, or who I am!" . . .

16 At this critical moment a fresh, comely woman pressed through the throng to get a peep at the gray-bearded man. She had a chubby child in her arms, which, frightened at his looks, began to cry. "Hush, Rip," cried she, "hush, you little fool; the old man won't hurt you." The name of the child, the air of the mother, the tone of her voice, all awakened a train of recollections in his mind. "What is your name, my good woman?" asked he.

17 "Judith Gardenier."

18 "And your father's name?"

19 "Ah, poor man, Rip Van Winkle was his name, but it's twenty years since he went away from home . . . I was then but a little girl." . . .

20 The honest man could contain himself no longer. He caught his daughter and her child in his arms. "I am your father!" cried he—"Young Rip Van Winkle once—old Rip Van Winkle now! Does nobody know poor Rip Van Winkle?"

21 All stood amazed, until an old woman tottering out from among the crowd, put her hand to her brow, and peering under it in his face for a moment, exclaimed, "Sure enough it is Rip Van Winkle—it is himself! Welcome home again, old neighbor—Why, where have you been these twenty long years?"

22 Rip's story was soon told, for the whole twenty years had been to him but as one night. The neighbors stared when they heard it; some were seen to wink at each other, and put their tongues in their cheeks; and the self-important man in the cocked hat, who when the alarm was over, had returned to the field, screwed down the corners of his mouth, and shook his head—upon which there was a general shaking of the head throughout the assemblage.

Excerpt from *Rip Van Winkle* by Washington Irving. In the public domain.

17. Read this sentence from the passage.

“The very village was altered; it was larger and more populous.”
(paragraph 2)

What does the word populous mean as it is used in the paragraph?

- Ⓐ crowded
- Ⓑ demanding
- Ⓒ natural
- Ⓓ welcoming

- 18.** How is Rip's perspective on the past different from those of the other characters?
- Ⓐ While Rip thinks he is a poor man, the people of the town think he is a famous politician.
 - Ⓑ While Rip thinks he went away to war temporarily, the people of the town think he is a stranger.
 - Ⓒ While Rip believes he traveled just up the mountain, the people of the town believe he journeyed far away.
 - Ⓓ While Rip believes he slept for one night, the people of the town believe that he was away for twenty years.

19. The Rebel archetype is often a misfit, and the Ruler archetype is often a leader. How do the “self-important man” and Rip Van Winkle represent these archetypes?

- Ⓐ Rip tries to figure out his own identity, while the self-important man wants to fool him.
- Ⓑ Rip treats the villagers with disrespect, and the self-important man is rude to him in return.
- Ⓒ Rip insists upon speaking to everyone, while the self-important man separates him from the crowd.
- Ⓓ Rip realizes that his experience is different from the others’, and the self-important man tries to exert control.

20. How does Rip try to convince the people of the town that he is not a spy?

- Ⓐ He compares the nature around him to what it used to look like.
- Ⓑ He provides names of people he knows to establish his credibility.
- Ⓒ He looks to the mountain to prove that he walked it and is one of them.
- Ⓓ He argues that he knows the jobs of people around him to establish a connection.

- 21.** Select the phrase that suggests that Rip is experiencing an unexpected welcome home.

“He had now ① entered the skirts of the village. A troop of ② strange children ran at his heels, hooting after him, and pointing at his gray beard. ③ The dogs, too, not one of which he recognized for ④ an old acquaintance, barked at him as he passed.” (paragraph 2)

- 22.** Two themes developed in the passage are that people should be confident in themselves and that people's identities are based on the world around them. How does the author develop these themes?
- Ⓐ by having Rip explain where he has been
 - Ⓑ by having Rip ask about his former friends
 - Ⓒ by having Rip repeatedly question his own truth
 - Ⓓ by having Rip describe what he remembers about the town

- 23.** Complete the table to show how various townspeople influence the development of the plot.

	The man who questions Rip	Rip's daughter	The crowd that gathers around Rip
emphasizes the spectacle of Rip's return	(A)	(B)	(C)
creates conflict while trying to find the truth about Rip	(D)	(E)	(F)
resolves the confusion over Rip's existence	(G)	(H)	(I)

24. How does Van Winkle's sudden arrival in town affect the plot?

- Ⓐ It startles the other characters and makes them wary.
- Ⓑ It convinces the daughter that Rip left town by mistake.
- Ⓒ It reminds the other characters of the reasons for the war.
- Ⓓ It reveals the way Rip is excited and willing to share his story.

Passage 1: Ripe Figs

by Kate Chopin

This story takes place in Louisiana in the late nineteenth century.

1 Maman-Nainaine said that when the figs were ripe Babette might go to visit her cousins down on the Bayou-Boeuf, where the sugar cane grows. Not that the ripening of figs had the least thing to do with it, but that is the way Maman-Nainaine was.

2 It seemed to Babette a very long time to wait; for the leaves upon the trees were tender yet, and the figs were like little hard, green marbles.

3 But warm rains came along and plenty of strong sunshine, and though Maman-Nainaine was as patient as the statue of la Madone, and Babette as restless as a humming-bird, the first thing they both knew it was hot summer-time. Every day Babette danced out to where the fig-trees were in a long line against the fence. She walked slowly beneath them, carefully peering between the gnarled, spreading branches. But each time she came disconsolate away again. What she saw there finally was something that made her sing and dance the whole long day.

4 When Maman-Nainaine sat down in her stately way to breakfast, the following morning . . . Babette approached. She bore a dainty porcelain platter, which she set down before her godmother. It contained a dozen purple figs, fringed around with their rich, green leaves.

5 “Ah,” said Maman-Nainaine, arching her eyebrows, “how early the figs have ripened this year!”

6 “Oh,” said Babette, “I think they have ripened very late.”

7 “Babette,” continued Maman-Nainaine, as she peeled the very plumpest figs with her pointed silver fruit-knife, “you will carry my love to them all down on Bayou-Boeuf. And tell your tante¹ Frosine I shall look for her at Toussaint²—when the chrysanthemums are in bloom.”

¹ tante: “aunt” in French

² Toussaint: a celebration in south Louisiana

Excerpt from “Ripe Figs” by Kate Chopin. In the public domain.

Passage 2: Youth

by Edgar Albert Guest

- 1 If I had youth I'd bid the world to try me;
I'd answer every challenge to my will.
Though mountains stood in silence to defy me,
I'd try to make them subject to my skill.
- 5 I'd keep my dreams and follow where they led me;
I'd glory in the hazards which abound.
I'd eat the simple fare privations fed me,
And gladly make my couch upon the ground.
- 10 If I had youth I'd ask no odds of distance,
Nor wish to tread the known and level ways.
I'd want to meet and master strong resistance,
And in a worth-while struggle spend my days.
I'd seek the task which calls for full endeavor;
I'd feel the thrill of battle in my veins.
- 15 I'd bear my burden gallantly, and never
Desert the hills to walk on common plains.
- 20 If I had youth no thought of failure lurking
Beyond to-morrow's dawn should fright my soul.
Let failure strike—it still should find me working
With faith that I should some day reach my goal.
I'd dice with danger—aye!—and glory in it;
I'd make high stakes the purpose of my throw.
I'd risk for much, and should I fail to win it,
I would not even whimper at the blow.
- 25 If I had youth no chains of fear should bind me;
I'd brave the heights which older men must shun.
I'd leave the well-worn lanes of life behind me,
And seek to do what men have never done.
Rich prizes wait for those who do not waver;
- 30 The world needs men to battle for the truth.
It calls each hour for stronger hearts and braver.
This is the age for those who still have youth!

"Youth" by Edgar Albert Guest, from *All That Matters*. In the public domain.

25. Read this sentence from Passage 1.

“But each time she came disconsolate away again.” (paragraph 3)

The word “console” comes from the Latin word for “to comfort.” Based on the affix and Latin root word, what is the meaning of the word disconsolate as it is used in paragraph 3?

- Ⓐ unable to accept
- Ⓑ in a confused state
- Ⓒ without cheer or hope
- Ⓓ with anger and annoyance

- 26.** Which event from Passage 1 does the author use to develop the difference in perspectives between Babette and Maman-Nainaine?
- Ⓐ Maman-Nainaine tells Babette that she may visit her cousins when the figs have ripened.
 - Ⓑ Maman-Nainaine waits patiently and Babette behaves restlessly as they wait for the figs to ripen.
 - Ⓒ Babette sings and dances when she sees the ripe figs and is eager to show them to Maman-Nainaine.
 - Ⓓ Babette presents the ripened figs to Maman-Nainaine on a plate made of fine porcelain for her breakfast.

27. Read these paragraphs from Passage 1.

5 “Ah,” said Maman-Nainaine, arching her eyebrows, “how early the
 figs have ripened this year!”

6 “Oh,” said Babette, “I think they have ripened very late.”

How do these paragraphs develop a distinction between Maman-Nainaine’s and Babette’s perspectives?

- Ⓐ They show that Maman-Nainaine treats Babette rudely.
- Ⓑ They demonstrate Babette’s attempt to stand up to her godmother.
- Ⓒ They reveal how Maman-Nainaine and Babette view the passage of time.
- Ⓓ They suggest that Babette’s youth prevents her from understanding her godmother.

28. Select **two** descriptions of how Maman-Nainaine is characterized in the context of her home in nineteenth-century Louisiana.

- Ⓐ as a proud woman who is comfortable in her role
- Ⓑ as an old-fashioned woman who longs for days gone by
- Ⓒ as a proper woman who is strict but keeps her promises
- Ⓓ as an aging woman who wishes she still had the energy of her youth
- Ⓔ as a lonely woman who bears some resentment toward other people

29. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Select **two** themes developed in Passage 1.

- Ⓐ People of all ages appreciate nature.
- Ⓑ Children must follow the advice of adults.
- Ⓒ People exhibit different levels of patience.
- Ⓓ The natural world is a mystery to children.
- Ⓔ Age and experience affect what people say and do.

Part B

Which detail from Passage 1 develops the themes in Part A?

- Ⓐ Babette wonders how the green marble-like figs of spring turned into ripe figs.
- Ⓑ Maman-Nainaine remembers what it was like to be a child who wants only to play.
- Ⓒ Babette likes to be outdoors, while Maman-Nainaine prefers a quiet home environment.
- Ⓓ Babette is eager to visit her cousins, but Maman-Nainaine makes her wait until the figs are ripe.

30. In Passage 1, what do the ripe figs symbolize?

- Ⓐ the joy of giving, as suggested by the gift Babette offers Maman-Nainaine
- Ⓑ growth and maturity, as seen in how the fruit is viewed by Babette and Maman-Nainaine
- Ⓒ birth and decay, as implied by the new fruit Babette brings to the aging Maman-Nainaine
- Ⓓ an appreciation for nature, as conveyed through how Babette and Maman-Nainaine interact with the natural world

31. Read these lines from Passage 2.

“Though mountains stood in silence to defy me,
I’d try to make them subject to my skill.” (lines 3–4)

How does the figurative language in lines 3–4 develop the speaker’s emotions?

- Ⓐ by revealing the speaker’s anger
- Ⓑ by demonstrating the determination of the speaker
- Ⓒ by showing the refusal of the speaker to remain quiet
- Ⓓ by conveying the speaker’s wish to learn more about nature

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32. The poet of Passage 2 uses the same structure for each of the poem’s stanzas, beginning with “If I had youth” and then developing the speaker’s ideas.

Complete the table to show what the speaker considers doing in each stanza.

	Stanza 1 (lines 1–8)	Stanza 2 (lines 9–16)	Stanza 4 (lines 25–32)
The speaker would do what others may have failed to accomplish.	Ⓐ	Ⓑ	Ⓒ
The speaker would be productive and work without complaint.	Ⓓ	Ⓔ	Ⓕ
The speaker would live simply and never give up.	Ⓖ	Ⓗ	Ⓘ

33. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Select **two** themes developed in Passage 2.

- Ⓐ Overcoming fears can be overwhelming.
- Ⓑ Growing old brings unhappiness and loss.
- Ⓒ People should lead full and useful lives when possible.
- Ⓓ Backing down from new opportunities may one day bring regret.
- Ⓔ The best advice comes from people who have experienced life to the fullest.

Part B

How does the poet develop the themes in Part A?

- Ⓐ by describing the simple life he wishes he could live
- Ⓑ by describing what he would do if he had his life to live over
- Ⓒ by describing decisions made by both young and old people
- Ⓓ by describing the kinds of battles he has had to fight regularly

34. How are the perspectives of Maman-Nainaine in Passage 1 and the speaker in Passage 2 different?

- Ⓐ While Maman-Nainaine seeks solitude, the speaker seeks a life filled with different kinds of people.
- Ⓑ While Maman-Nainaine has accepted her place in society, the speaker feels lost in a confusing world.
- Ⓒ While Maman-Nainaine expects obedience from other people, the speaker wants to show his obedience to others.
- Ⓓ While Maman-Nainaine demonstrates satisfaction with her life, the speaker regrets not living a more courageous life.

35. Which archetype does the speaker in Passage 2 praise?

- Ⓐ The Explorer, who is searching for a life of purpose
- Ⓑ The Artist, who endeavors to add beauty to the world
- Ⓒ The Innocent, who is inexperienced and seeks the safety of others
- Ⓓ The Caregiver, who provides support and offers help to those in need

36. The archetype Death and Rebirth symbolizes the circle of life.

Complete the table to show how each passage illustrates The Death and Rebirth archetype.

	Passage 1	Passage 2	Both Passages
The passage shows the cyclical development of nature’s bounty.	(A)	(B)	(C)
The passage contrasts the outlooks and lives of people of different generations.	(D)	(E)	(F)
The passage offers personal reflections and a desire to give rebirth to one’s self.	(G)	(H)	(I)



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Test Release: 2025

Sports Are Great Because They're Pointless

by Arthur C. Brooks

- 1 Even though I've never lived in Chicago, I have a soft spot for the Cubs. My father grew up in the Windy City and loved the team his whole life. And I loved my dad. So, by the transitive property,¹ I loved the Cubs too. Two decades after my father's death, I am still a fan. Every time I watch the Cubs on television, I think of him and have a conversation with him in my head about the game.
- 2 Perhaps baseball strikes you as too trivial a thing for father and son to connect over. Maybe we could have bonded more through our shared vocation (I am an academic, like he was—and like his father was too), or our feelings toward our relatives. Compared with family and career concerns, a ball game might seem, frankly, sort of useless.
- 3 But that is precisely what makes it ideal for forming relationships. In a transactional world, our relationships with others tend to become part of a web of useful alliances. But such alliances make for the least satisfying relationships. If you are finding that your closest bonds of friendship and family leave you feeling empty, the solution is not to make your relationships more practical. It is to organize them more around things that aren't useful at all—like baseball.
- 4 When it comes to understanding our relationships with others, for my money, the best source is Aristotle. He wrote extensively about the many types of *philia*, or the mutual attraction and attachment that form the basis of every relationship between human beings. *Philia* based on transaction is the least virtuous kind, according to Aristotle. For example, I am friendly with my dentist, and she is friendly with me, which makes it less unpleasant for me to give her hundreds of dollars to drill my teeth. At the other end of the spectrum is *philia* based simply on the deep satisfaction that a relationship brings to each person in it, and a desire that the other be happy. They "wish each alike the other's good," Aristotle wrote.
- 5 This highest *philia* often includes a common love for a third thing, such as religious faith or a search for moral perfection. I have one close friendship, for example, in which my friend and I frequently discuss our efforts at improving ourselves as people. But as research has shown in the more than 2,400 years since Aristotle described *philia*, a mutual love doesn't have to be for something profound in order for it to bolster a deep friendship. Just as the highest *philia* is not "useful" in a worldly sense, the love that sustains it can be for something that might seem trivial. The point is that it brings friends together in shared satisfaction, without being transactional.

¹ transitive property: the concept that if A=B and B=C, then A=C

- 6 And this brings me back to the Cubs, the team that brought me together with my dad We had nothing to gain as we watched them play, except for the satisfaction of enjoying the games together as father and son, a satisfaction that was much greater than it would have been had either of us watched without the other. The Cubs were the “place” where we met to enjoy our bond.
- 7 Lots of sports fans have similar experiences. In their forthcoming book, *Fans Have More Friends*, the sportswriters Ben Valenta and David Sikorjak find that the biggest enthusiasts have the best social lives. The authors measured the intensity of one’s love for sports—they call it “fandom”—by people’s self-rated passion as well as the time they spend watching and participating; they then compared that with the quality of people’s friendships and family life. The relationships are correlative² but striking. For example, 42 percent of the most involved sports fans were “very satisfied” with their family life, compared with less than a quarter of nonfans. Sixty-one percent of fans, but only 37 percent of nonfans, said they “felt close to people.”
- 8 These findings are consistent with past research on sports fans. Scholars have found that both fandom and fan loyalty are positively associated with a sense of belonging and a sense of meaning. One study from last year showed that active sports participation actually *causes* greater life satisfaction. And in a 2009 study of 900 people who played sports in the Netherlands, a third said that they “generated their social networks, their self-esteem and trust in others primarily through sport.” Sports are just one example; research shows that people bond in meaningful ways over all kinds of impractical things, from classic cars to birdhouses to cheesy TV.
- 9 If your relationships with friends and family are leaving you a little cold, you might be suffering from excessive usefulness in your activities. Maybe the solution is cultivating a taste for baseball, or maybe instead for opera, chess, or *Jeopardy*. No matter what your friendship-boosting hobby is, be sure to follow two rules.

1) Make it intrinsic, not instrumental.

- 10 Remember that Aristotle’s perfect *philia* requires you to focus on the inherent satisfaction you get from someone’s company, not worldly gains such as money or career advancement. Your pastime should mostly serve that satisfaction goal. . . .

2) The point is *philia*, not passion.

- 11 If I am to be truthful with you, I am not authentically passionate about any pastimes, and I never have been. I envy people who honestly seem to *love* college football, whittling, or singing in a

² correlative: connected, corresponding

community choir, because I am not one of them. That doesn't stop me from achieving perfect *philia*, however. You can still form a bond with someone you appreciate by dabbling in something you like but don't love. To cultivate better *philia*, don't pretend to enjoy something you really hate. But do consider what your loved ones enjoy, and if those interests appeal to you at all, you can adopt them by choice.

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1. How do paragraphs 10–11 add meaning to the passage?

- Ⓐ by examining how one person can share a hobby with a larger group
- Ⓑ by giving advice about incorporating common interests into relationships
- Ⓒ by emphasizing how some hobbies promote friendships more than others
- Ⓓ by highlighting how theories about attachment continue to change over time

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 67%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how individual text sections and/or features convey a purpose and/or meaning in texts.

2. How does the title of the passage relate to the author's overall point?

- Ⓐ by introducing a unique perspective on a common topic
- Ⓑ by demonstrating how specific activities should be organized
- Ⓒ by giving an example of how to make interests more purposeful
- Ⓓ by expressing the frustration that can develop in some situations

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 60%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how individual text sections and/or features convey a purpose and/or meaning in texts.

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3. How does the story of his father in paragraph 1 contribute to the author's purpose?
- Ⓐ It uses a logical appeal to explain his doubts about why he continues to enjoy baseball.
 - Ⓑ It uses a logical appeal to demonstrate why his father wanted to teach him how to play sports.
 - Ⓒ It uses an emotional appeal to connect his love for his father to his support for a specific sports team.
 - Ⓓ It uses an emotional appeal to describe why his childhood memories of baseball are hard for him to remember.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 80%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.3

Benchmark Description: Explain how an author establishes and achieves purpose(s) through rhetorical appeals and/or figurative language.

4. Read this sentence from the passage.

“In a transactional world, our relationships with others tend to become part of a web of useful alliances.” (paragraph 3)

How does the figurative language in this sentence support the author’s advice about relationships?

- Ⓐ It reveals why some relationships are long lasting.
- Ⓑ It acknowledges how comfortable some relationships can be.
- Ⓒ It describes relationships that are based on personal benefits.
- Ⓓ It highlights specific differences between types of relationships.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 47%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.3

Benchmark Description: Explain how an author establishes and achieves purpose(s) through rhetorical appeals and/or figurative language.

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5. Select **two** ways the author supports the claim that relationships based on money struggle to develop *philia* in paragraph 4.

- ☒ Ⓐ He uses a personal example.
- ☐ Ⓑ He includes the results of a study.
- ☒ Ⓒ He cites the opinion of a historical figure.
- ☐ Ⓓ He compares amateur athletes with fans.
- ☐ Ⓔ He summarizes the responses from a survey.

Answer Key: A, C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 50%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.4

Benchmark Description: Track the development of an argument, analyzing the types of reasoning used and their effectiveness, identifying ways in which the argument could be improved.

6. How does the author use logical reasoning to develop the argument that *philia* can come from a variety of hobbies?

- Ⓐ He explores the particular case of sports to build to a general statement about all hobbies.
- Ⓑ He starts with a general claim about hobbies and then applies that claim to sports specifically.
- Ⓒ He focuses on how hobbies affected one relationship and then expands that pattern to his other relationships.
- Ⓓ He notices how he feels about one hobby and then concludes that hobbies are the best way to improve happiness.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 30%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.4

Benchmark Description: Track the development of an argument, analyzing the types of reasoning used and their effectiveness, identifying ways in which the argument could be improved.

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7. Select the detail that helps to explain the meaning of the word trivial.

- 2 Ⓐ Perhaps baseball strikes you as too trivial a thing for
 Ⓑ father and son to connect over. Maybe we could have bonded
 more through Ⓒ our shared vocation (I am an academic, like he
 was—and like his father was too), or our feelings Ⓓ toward our
 relatives. Compared with family and career concerns, a ball game
 might seem, frankly, Ⓔ sort of useless.

Answer Key: E

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 44%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.V.1.3

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of context clues, figurative language, word relationships, reference materials, and/or background knowledge to determine the connotative and denotative meaning of words and phrases, appropriate to grade level.

8. Read this sentence from the passage.

“Even though I’ve never lived in Chicago, I have a soft spot for the Cubs.” (paragraph 1)

What does the phrase “a soft spot” suggest?

- Ⓐ a confusing opinion
- Ⓑ an interesting fanbase
- Ⓒ a comfortable location
- Ⓓ an emotional attachment

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 82%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how figurative language contributes to meaning and explain examples of symbolism in text(s).

Passage 1: Why Do People Love Games?

by Sam Von Ehren

- 1 Why do people love games? As the Game Maker for The New York Times, I grapple with this question every day. The reductively easy answer is simple: They're fun! But why are they fun? Do they have to be fun? As we dig deeper and deeper, we find more questions. What even is a game? What is fun? My take on the appeal of games is also simple, if paradoxical. Games are a controlled form of freedom. Our brains grab onto them because they are structures that exist to be avoided.
- 2 Games occupy a strange place in our cultural consciousness. Nearly everyone has played a game at some point in their lives. Despite that ubiquity, games are rarely discussed with the same reverence as other media like films or books. For most, games are like chocolate: a guilty pleasure consumed secretly. The game designer Sid Meier once remarked that "a game is a series of interesting choices." Navigating these choices shapes the course of play, revealing who we are and how we think. Playing a game is an act of exposition. . . .
- 3 Imagine a circle drawn in chalk on a sidewalk. When we are inside the chalk we are "playing" the game. We'll only do what the rules of the game allow. We will try to win. When the game ends, we leave the circle and return to normal. The magic circle is what separates a game from reality.
- 4 I use the metaphor of a chalk line because the magic circle is not an absolute barrier or even a physical one. We can enter and exit the magic circle freely. We bring our bodies, personalities, and life experiences into the game. We take the memories and experience of the game with us when we leave. The chalk line casts a spell on that space of sidewalk and turns it into a space for playing. . . .
- 5 Humans have always been drawn to this trick, finding novel ways to play within their environments. In prehistoric times, humans were playing games with sheep ankle bones called Knucklebones. These oddly shaped bones afforded a game similar to jacks. Players balance a few bones on top of their hands, then toss a few in the air, capturing as many as possible on the way down. Go, a strategy game invented in ancient China, is still played, highlighting part of what is so fascinating about games. Although Go's origin is unclear, many scholars speculate that it was created to teach tactics and strategy. When we enter the magic circle, we give ourselves permission to explore, to fail, to lose. When we stop playing Go, we carry that experience with us. The same is true for Chess, Poker, or any number of analog games.

- 6 Digital games take many of the powers of traditional analog games and ramp up both the rate of interaction and the complexity of the underlying systems. A digital game takes input from the player 60 times per second, resolves it with a potentially very complicated rule set, and renders a new image of the game state. This rapid feedback loop engages our proprioception, that is our sense of embodiment and physicality. Digital games are powerfully compelling as a result, but I often find that analog games are a bit more playful. When playing an analog game, the only limitations are the rules you’ve agreed to, you can modify and change them at will, more easily creating playful experiences.

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Passage 2: Video games level up life skills

by Kathryn Hulick

- 7 When gamers band together to defeat a three-headed zombie dragon boss, they may not be thinking much about school or work. Still, they are likely building skills that will come in handy in the real world, a new study finds. Researchers in Scotland found that playing video games in a group can improve young adults’ communication skills and resourcefulness. It also can make them better at *adapting* to new situations.
- 8 Sharpening those skills can help someone get a job or advance in a career. “Employers want you to think for yourself and adapt to changing situations,” says Matthew Barr, who conducted the new study. He studies video games and gamer culture at the University of Glasgow in Scotland. He also played a lot of video games while growing up.
- 9 From his own experience, Barr knows that video games demand quick thinking. “Games are always keeping you on your toes. You have to be able to figure out what to do if you’re just dropped into a situation,” he says. Multiplayer games also require good communication among players.
- 10 Barr wanted to know whether these gaming skills carry over into real life. So he recruited 16 university students to play eight different video games. The students played in a computer lab over an eight-week period. They could come and go whenever they wanted to, but each had to play for a total of 14 hours.

- 11 Another group of students did not play any games at the lab. This was the *control group*. To understand the effect of a change in behavior, scientists must compare at least two groups. One or more groups will change their behavior. The control group, in contrast, makes no changes.
- 12 The games covered a variety of genres. . . . Six of the games in the study included ways for players to work together in the game itself. Two of the games were single-player only. But the students talked through these games as they played. So all of the games prompted conversation and cooperation.
- 13 Both before and after the study, students in both groups filled out three questionnaires about their real-life skills. One measured their communication skills, such as talking and listening. Another measured adaptability. This investigated how well people deal with changing situations. The third questionnaire looked at resourcefulness. This includes problem-solving and knowing when to ask for help. . . .
- 14 Barr found that after two months of playing video games regularly, students' scores on all three skills improved. Resourcefulness scores increased significantly for 81 percent of the gamers. Adaptability scores increased for 75 percent. And communication skills scores increased for 69 percent of gamers.
- 15 In contrast, fewer than half of the students in the control group improved their scores in each of the three areas.
- 16 Barr's results appear in the October issue of *Computers & Education*.

Part of the team

- 17 Barr also interviewed the study participants about the experience. Several students told him that playing games on a team helped to not only break down their anxieties but also to build their confidence. In that sense, he believes sports and video games may build similar life skills. "It's kind of like joining the hockey team," he says.
- 18 Barr thinks schools should have video games as extracurricular activities—just like sports. A school could set up a video game room, for example, or start a gaming club on campus.
- 19 Beverley Oliver is an expert in education at Deakin University in Melbourne, Australia. She wasn't involved in the study. She isn't convinced that schools should add a video game room. "Playing games develops skills," she says. "This is no surprise." But that's not only true of video games. The game could just as easily be hopscotch or Monopoly, she notes. And there are other ways to sharpen the same life skills that might also improve with gaming. . . .

- 20 Barr points out that other skill-building activities, such as traditional sports, aren't for everybody. Video games may be a more fun or effective way for certain students to gain the same kinds of skills. In his opinion, the study results are a perfect excuse to get your game on.

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9. “As the Game Maker for The New York Times, I grapple with this question every day.” (paragraph 1)

What is the meaning of the phrase grapple with as it is used in this sentence?

- Ⓐ answer
- Ⓑ consider
- Ⓒ repeat
- Ⓓ simplify

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 49%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.V.1.3

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of context clues, figurative language, word relationships, reference materials, and/or background knowledge to determine the connotative and denotative meaning of words and phrases, appropriate to grade level.

10. How does the author of Passage 1 develop his argument about digital versus analog games?

- Ⓐ by describing the limitations of analog games
- Ⓑ by describing the origins and purposes of digital games
- Ⓒ by explaining that digital games are too similar to each other
- Ⓓ by explaining that analog games have fewer and more flexible rules

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 44%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.4

Benchmark Description: Track the development of an argument, analyzing the types of reasoning used and their effectiveness, identifying ways in which the argument could be improved.

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11. How do paragraphs 3–4 contribute to Passage 1?

- Ⓐ by describing ways that players can change a game to become more engaging
- Ⓑ by explaining elements and benefits of a game that players of the game may not realize
- Ⓒ by describing a simple and common game that can feel magical if played for long enough
- Ⓓ by explaining circumstances in which a game becomes too complicated for average players

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 49%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how individual text sections and/or features convey a purpose and/or meaning in texts.

12. How does the **Part of the team** section add to the purpose of Passage 2? Select **two** answers.

- ☒ Ⓐ by describing the appeal of playing video games
- ☒ Ⓑ by emphasizing that video games involve cooperation
- ☐ Ⓒ by suggesting that video games work best with many players
- ☐ Ⓓ by explaining how video games were built to model traditional games
- ☐ Ⓔ by arguing that kids who enjoy sports will like video games even more

Answer Key: A, B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 29%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how individual text sections and/or features convey a purpose and/or meaning in texts.

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13. How do the rhetorical questions in paragraph 1 of Passage 1 support the author’s appeal?

- Ⓐ They encourage the reader to consider why games are popular.
- Ⓑ They share thoughts that fans have submitted regarding games.
- Ⓒ They show that people prefer games with friends over solo games.
- Ⓓ They urge the reader to reconsider what types of games are preferred.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 70%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain how an author uses rhetorical devices to support or advance an appeal.

14. Read this sentence from Passage 2.

“Several students told him that playing games on a team helped to not only break down their anxieties but also to build their confidence.”
(paragraph 17)

How do the phrases “break down their anxieties” and “build their confidence” advance the author’s appeal?

- Ⓐ It challenges previous opinions about video games.
- Ⓑ It introduces other powerful life benefits of video games.
- Ⓒ It implies that students prefer studies conducted by professors.
- Ⓓ It emphasizes the types of students who participated in the study.

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 78%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain how an author uses rhetorical devices to support or advance an appeal.

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15. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Select **two** central ideas of Passage 1.

- ☐ Ⓐ Games have proven essential for childhood growth.
- ☒ Ⓑ Games are an important part of the human experience.
- ☐ Ⓒ The definition of a game has changed frequently over time.
- ☐ Ⓓ The differences between digital and analog games are vast.
- ☒ Ⓔ Games have many forms and are valuable in different ways.

Part B

Which detail from the passage supports the **two** central ideas from Part A?

- ☐ Ⓐ “As we dig deeper and deeper, we find more questions.” (paragraph 1)
- ☒ Ⓑ “Navigating these choices shapes the course of play, revealing who we are and how we think.” (paragraph 2)
- ☐ Ⓒ “Players balance a few bones on top of their hands, then toss a few in the air, capturing as many as possible on the way down.” (paragraph 5)
- ☐ Ⓓ “This rapid feedback loop engages our proprioception, that is our sense of embodiment and physicality.” (paragraph 6)

Answer Key: B, E and B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 30%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.2.2

Benchmark Description: Analyze two or more central ideas and their development throughout a text.

16. Read this sentence from Passage 1.

“Digital games take many of the powers of traditional analog games and ramp up both the rate of interaction and the complexity of the underlying systems.” (paragraph 6)

The word “complexity” comes from a Latin word meaning “connected.” Based on this information, what is the meaning of complexity as it is used in this sentence?

- Ⓐ puzzle
- Ⓑ typical use
- Ⓒ momentum
- Ⓓ advanced level

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 57%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.V.1.2

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of Greek and Latin roots and affixes to determine meanings of words and phrases in grade-level content.

from *Rip Van Winkle*

by Washington Irving

One night, Rip Van Winkle encountered a strange and unsettling group of men. He observed their party and had some of their drink before falling into a deep sleep. He is now heading back home on what he believes is the next morning.

- 1 As he approached the village, he met a number of people, but none whom he knew, which somewhat surprised him, for he had thought himself acquainted with every one in the country round. Their dress, too, was of a different fashion from that to which he was accustomed. They all stared at him with equal marks of surprise, and whenever they cast their eyes upon him, invariably stroked their chins. The constant recurrence of this gesture induced Rip, involuntarily, to do the same, when, to his astonishment, he found his beard had grown a foot long!
- 2 He had now entered the skirts of the village. A troop of strange children ran at his heels, hooting after him, and pointing at his gray beard. The dogs, too, not one of which he recognized for an old acquaintance, barked at him as he passed. The very village was altered; it was larger and more populous. There were rows of houses which he had never seen before, and those which had been his familiar haunts had disappeared. Strange names were over the doors—strange faces at the windows,—everything was strange. His mind now misgave him; he began to doubt whether both he and the world around him were not bewitched. Surely this was his native village, which he had left but the day before. There stood the Kaatskill Mountains—there ran the silver Hudson at a distance—there was every hill and dale precisely as it had always been—Rip was sorely perplexed. . . .
- 3 The appearance of Rip, with his long grizzled beard, his rusty fowling-piece, his uncouth dress, and an army of women and children at his heels, soon attracted the attention of the tavern-politicians. They crowded round him, eying him from head to foot with great curiosity. The orator bustled up to him, and, drawing him partly aside, inquired “on which side he voted?” . . . Rip was equally at a loss to comprehend the question; when a knowing, self-important old gentleman, in a sharp cocked hat, made his way through the crowd, putting them to the right and left with his elbows as he passed, and planting himself before Van Winkle, with one arm akimbo, the other resting on his cane, his keen eyes and sharp hat penetrating, as it were, into his very soul, demanded in an austere tone, “what brought

him to the election with . . . a mob at his heels, and whether he meant to breed a riot in the village?" — "Alas! gentlemen," cried Rip, somewhat dismayed, "I am a poor quiet man, a native of the place, and a loyal subject of the king, God bless him!"

4 Here a general shout burst from the bystanders—"A tory! a tory! a spy! a refugee! hustle him! away with him!" It was with great difficulty that the self-important man in the cocked hat restored order; and, having assumed a tenfold austerity of brow, demanded again of the unknown culprit what he came there for, and whom he was seeking? The poor man humbly assured him that he meant no harm, but merely came there in search of some of his neighbors, who used to keep about the tavern.

5 "Well—who are they?—name them."

6 Rip bethought himself a moment, and inquired, "Where's Nicholas Vedder?"

7 There was a silence for a little while, when an old man replied, in a thin, piping voice: "Nicholas Vedder? why, he is dead and gone these eighteen years! There was a wooden tombstone in the churchyard that used to tell all about him, but that's rotten and gone too."

8 "Where's Brom Dutcher?"

9 "Oh, he went off to the army in the beginning of the war . . . I don't know—he never came back again."

10 "Where's Van Bummel, the school-master?"

11 "He went off to the wars too, was a great militia general, and is now in Congress."

12 Rip's heart died away, at hearing of these sad changes in his home and friends, and finding himself thus alone in the world. Every answer puzzled him too, by treating of such enormous lapses of time, and of matters which he could not understand: war—Congress; he had no courage to ask after any more friends, but cried out in despair, "Does nobody here know Rip Van Winkle?"

13 "Oh, Rip Van Winkle!" exclaimed two or three, "Oh, to be sure! that's Rip Van Winkle yonder, leaning against the tree."

14 Rip looked, and beheld a precise counterpart of himself, as he went up the mountain: apparently as lazy, and certainly as ragged. The poor fellow was now completely confounded. He doubted his own identity, and whether he was himself or another man. In the midst of his bewilderment, the man in the cocked hat demanded who he was, and what was his name?

15 "God knows," exclaimed he, at his wit's end; "I'm not myself—I'm somebody else—that's me yonder—no—that's somebody else got into my shoes—I was myself last night, but I fell asleep on the mountain, . . .

and everything's changed, and I'm changed, and I can't tell what's my name, or who I am!" . . .

16 At this critical moment a fresh, comely woman pressed through the throng to get a peep at the gray-bearded man. She had a chubby child in her arms, which, frightened at his looks, began to cry. "Hush, Rip," cried she, "hush, you little fool; the old man won't hurt you." The name of the child, the air of the mother, the tone of her voice, all awakened a train of recollections in his mind. "What is your name, my good woman?" asked he.

17 "Judith Gardenier."

18 "And your father's name?"

19 "Ah, poor man, Rip Van Winkle was his name, but it's twenty years since he went away from home . . . I was then but a little girl." . . .

20 The honest man could contain himself no longer. He caught his daughter and her child in his arms. "I am your father!" cried he—"Young Rip Van Winkle once—old Rip Van Winkle now! Does nobody know poor Rip Van Winkle?"

21 All stood amazed, until an old woman tottering out from among the crowd, put her hand to her brow, and peering under it in his face for a moment, exclaimed, "Sure enough it is Rip Van Winkle—it is himself! Welcome home again, old neighbor—Why, where have you been these twenty long years?"

22 Rip's story was soon told, for the whole twenty years had been to him but as one night. The neighbors stared when they heard it; some were seen to wink at each other, and put their tongues in their cheeks; and the self-important man in the cocked hat, who when the alarm was over, had returned to the field, screwed down the corners of his mouth, and shook his head—upon which there was a general shaking of the head throughout the assemblage.

Excerpt from *Rip Van Winkle* by Washington Irving. In the public domain.

17. Read this sentence from the passage.

“The very village was altered; it was larger and more populous.”
(paragraph 2)

What does the word populous mean as it is used in the paragraph?

- ☒ (A) crowded
- ☐ (B) demanding
- ☐ (C) natural
- ☐ (D) welcoming

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 88%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.V.1.3

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of context clues, figurative language, word relationships, reference materials, and/or background knowledge to determine the connotative and denotative meaning of words and phrases, appropriate to grade level.

Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

- 18.** How is Rip’s perspective on the past different from those of the other characters?
- Ⓐ While Rip thinks he is a poor man, the people of the town think he is a famous politician.
 - Ⓑ While Rip thinks he went away to war temporarily, the people of the town think he is a stranger.
 - Ⓒ While Rip believes he traveled just up the mountain, the people of the town believe he journeyed far away.
 - Ⓓ While Rip believes he slept for one night, the people of the town believe that he was away for twenty years.

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 62%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.3

Benchmark Description: Analyze how an author develops and individualizes the perspectives of different characters.

Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

- 19.** The Rebel archetype is often a misfit, and the Ruler archetype is often a leader. How do the “self-important man” and Rip Van Winkle represent these archetypes?
- Ⓐ Rip tries to figure out his own identity, while the self-important man wants to fool him.
 - Ⓑ Rip treats the villagers with disrespect, and the self-important man is rude to him in return.
 - Ⓒ Rip insists upon speaking to everyone, while the self-important man separates him from the crowd.
 - Ⓓ Rip realizes that his experience is different from the others’, and the self-important man tries to exert control.

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 36%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.3

Benchmark Description: Compare and contrast the use or discussion of archetypes in texts.

20. How does Rip try to convince the people of the town that he is not a spy?

- Ⓐ He compares the nature around him to what it used to look like.
- Ⓑ He provides names of people he knows to establish his credibility.
- Ⓒ He looks to the mountain to prove that he walked it and is one of them.
- Ⓓ He argues that he knows the jobs of people around him to establish a connection.

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 70%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain how an author uses rhetorical devices to support or advance an appeal.

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21. Select the phrase that suggests that Rip is experiencing an unexpected welcome home.

“He had now ① entered the skirts of the village. A troop of ② strange children ran at his heels, hooting after him, and pointing at his gray beard. ③ The dogs, too, not one of which he recognized for ④ an old acquaintance, barked at him as he passed.” (paragraph 2)

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 76%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how figurative language contributes to meaning and explain examples of symbolism in text(s).

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22. Two themes developed in the passage are that people should be confident in themselves and that people’s identities are based on the world around them. How does the author develop these themes?

- Ⓐ by having Rip explain where he has been
- Ⓑ by having Rip ask about his former friends
- Ⓒ by having Rip repeatedly question his own truth
- Ⓓ by having Rip describe what he remembers about the town

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 49%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.2

Benchmark Description: Analyze two or more themes and their development throughout a literary text.

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- 23.** Complete the table to show how various townspeople influence the development of the plot.

	The man who questions Rip	Rip's daughter	The crowd that gathers around Rip
emphasizes the spectacle of Rip's return	(A)	(B)	(C)
creates conflict while trying to find the truth about Rip	(D)	(E)	(F)
resolves the confusion over Rip's existence	(G)	(H)	(I)

Answer Key: C, D, H

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 44%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze the interaction between character development, setting, and plot in a literary text.

24. How does Van Winkle’s sudden arrival in town affect the plot?

- Ⓐ It startles the other characters and makes them wary.
- Ⓑ It convinces the daughter that Rip left town by mistake.
- Ⓒ It reminds the other characters of the reasons for the war.
- Ⓓ It reveals the way Rip is excited and willing to share his story.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 65%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze the interaction between character development, setting, and plot in a literary text.

Passage 1: Ripe Figs

by Kate Chopin

This story takes place in Louisiana in the late nineteenth century.

1 Maman-Nainaine said that when the figs were ripe Babette might go to visit her cousins down on the Bayou-Boeuf, where the sugar cane grows. Not that the ripening of figs had the least thing to do with it, but that is the way Maman-Nainaine was.

2 It seemed to Babette a very long time to wait; for the leaves upon the trees were tender yet, and the figs were like little hard, green marbles.

3 But warm rains came along and plenty of strong sunshine, and though Maman-Nainaine was as patient as the statue of la Madone, and Babette as restless as a humming-bird, the first thing they both knew it was hot summer-time. Every day Babette danced out to where the fig-trees were in a long line against the fence. She walked slowly beneath them, carefully peering between the gnarled, spreading branches. But each time she came disconsolate away again. What she saw there finally was something that made her sing and dance the whole long day.

4 When Maman-Nainaine sat down in her stately way to breakfast, the following morning . . . Babette approached. She bore a dainty porcelain platter, which she set down before her godmother. It contained a dozen purple figs, fringed around with their rich, green leaves.

5 “Ah,” said Maman-Nainaine, arching her eyebrows, “how early the figs have ripened this year!”

6 “Oh,” said Babette, “I think they have ripened very late.”

7 “Babette,” continued Maman-Nainaine, as she peeled the very plumpest figs with her pointed silver fruit-knife, “you will carry my love to them all down on Bayou-Boeuf. And tell your tante¹ Frosine I shall look for her at Toussaint²—when the chrysanthemums are in bloom.”

¹ tante: “aunt” in French

² Toussaint: a celebration in south Louisiana

Excerpt from “Ripe Figs” by Kate Chopin. In the public domain.

Passage 2: Youth

by Edgar Albert Guest

- 1 If I had youth I'd bid the world to try me;
I'd answer every challenge to my will.
Though mountains stood in silence to defy me,
I'd try to make them subject to my skill.
- 5 I'd keep my dreams and follow where they led me;
I'd glory in the hazards which abound.
I'd eat the simple fare privations fed me,
And gladly make my couch upon the ground.
- 10 If I had youth I'd ask no odds of distance,
Nor wish to tread the known and level ways.
I'd want to meet and master strong resistance,
And in a worth-while struggle spend my days.
I'd seek the task which calls for full endeavor;
I'd feel the thrill of battle in my veins.
- 15 I'd bear my burden gallantly, and never
Desert the hills to walk on common plains.
- 20 If I had youth no thought of failure lurking
Beyond to-morrow's dawn should fright my soul.
Let failure strike—it still should find me working
With faith that I should some day reach my goal.
I'd dice with danger—aye!—and glory in it;
I'd make high stakes the purpose of my throw.
I'd risk for much, and should I fail to win it,
I would not even whimper at the blow.
- 25 If I had youth no chains of fear should bind me;
I'd brave the heights which older men must shun.
I'd leave the well-worn lanes of life behind me,
And seek to do what men have never done.
Rich prizes wait for those who do not waver;
- 30 The world needs men to battle for the truth.
It calls each hour for stronger hearts and braver.
This is the age for those who still have youth!

"Youth" by Edgar Albert Guest, from *All That Matters*. In the public domain.

25. Read this sentence from Passage 1.

“But each time she came disconsolate away again.” (paragraph 3)

The word “console” comes from the Latin word for “to comfort.” Based on the affix and Latin root word, what is the meaning of the word disconsolate as it is used in paragraph 3?

- Ⓐ unable to accept
- Ⓑ in a confused state
- Ⓒ without cheer or hope
- Ⓓ with anger and annoyance

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 51%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.V.1.2

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of Greek and Latin roots and affixes to determine meanings of words and phrases in grade-level content.

Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

- 26.** Which event from Passage 1 does the author use to develop the difference in perspectives between Babette and Maman-Nainaine?
- Ⓐ Maman-Nainaine tells Babette that she may visit her cousins when the figs have ripened.
 - Ⓑ Maman-Nainaine waits patiently and Babette behaves restlessly as they wait for the figs to ripen.
 - Ⓒ Babette sings and dances when she sees the ripe figs and is eager to show them to Maman-Nainaine.
 - Ⓓ Babette presents the ripened figs to Maman-Nainaine on a plate made of fine porcelain for her breakfast.

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 64%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.3

Benchmark Description: Analyze how an author develops and individualizes the perspectives of different characters.

27. Read these paragraphs from Passage 1.

- 5 “Ah,” said Maman-Nainaine, arching her eyebrows, “how early the
 figs have ripened this year!”
- 6 “Oh,” said Babette, “I think they have ripened very late.”

How do these paragraphs develop a distinction between Maman-Nainaine’s and Babette’s perspectives?

- Ⓐ They show that Maman-Nainaine treats Babette rudely.
- Ⓑ They demonstrate Babette’s attempt to stand up to her godmother.
- Ⓒ They reveal how Maman-Nainaine and Babette view the passage of time.
- Ⓓ They suggest that Babette’s youth prevents her from understanding her godmother.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 64%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.3

Benchmark Description: Analyze how an author develops and individualizes the perspectives of different characters.

Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

28. Select **two** descriptions of how Maman-Nainaine is characterized in the context of her home in nineteenth-century Louisiana.

- ☒ Ⓐ as a proud woman who is comfortable in her role
- ☐ Ⓑ as an old-fashioned woman who longs for days gone by
- ☒ Ⓒ as a proper woman who is strict but keeps her promises
- ☐ Ⓓ as an aging woman who wishes she still had the energy of her youth
- ☐ Ⓔ as a lonely woman who bears some resentment toward other people

Answer Key: A, C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 28%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze the interaction between character development, setting, and plot in a literary text.

29. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Select **two** themes developed in Passage 1.

- Ⓐ People of all ages appreciate nature.
- Ⓑ Children must follow the advice of adults.
- Ⓒ People exhibit different levels of patience.
- Ⓓ The natural world is a mystery to children.
- Ⓔ Age and experience affect what people say and do.

Part B

Which detail from Passage 1 develops the themes in Part A?

- Ⓐ Babette wonders how the green marble-like figs of spring turned into ripe figs.
- Ⓑ Maman-Nainaine remembers what it was like to be a child who wants only to play.
- Ⓒ Babette likes to be outdoors, while Maman-Nainaine prefers a quiet home environment.
- Ⓓ Babette is eager to visit her cousins, but Maman-Nainaine makes her wait until the figs are ripe.

Answer Key: C, E and D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 26%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.2

Benchmark Description: Analyze two or more themes and their development throughout a literary text.

Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

30. In Passage 1, what do the ripe figs symbolize?

- Ⓐ the joy of giving, as suggested by the gift Babette offers Maman-Nainaine
- Ⓑ growth and maturity, as seen in how the fruit is viewed by Babette and Maman-Nainaine
- Ⓒ birth and decay, as implied by the new fruit Babette brings to the aging Maman-Nainaine
- Ⓓ an appreciation for nature, as conveyed through how Babette and Maman-Nainaine interact with the natural world

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 52%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how figurative language contributes to meaning and explain examples of symbolism in text(s).

31. Read these lines from Passage 2.

“Though mountains stood in silence to defy me,
I’d try to make them subject to my skill.” (lines 3–4)

How does the figurative language in lines 3–4 develop the speaker’s emotions?

- Ⓐ by revealing the speaker’s anger
- Ⓑ by demonstrating the determination of the speaker
- Ⓒ by showing the refusal of the speaker to remain quiet
- Ⓓ by conveying the speaker’s wish to learn more about nature

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 71%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain how an author uses rhetorical devices to support or advance an appeal.

Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

- 32.** The poet of Passage 2 uses the same structure for each of the poem’s stanzas, beginning with “If I had youth” and then developing the speaker’s ideas.

Complete the table to show what the speaker considers doing in each stanza.

	Stanza 1 (lines 1–8)	Stanza 2 (lines 9–16)	Stanza 4 (lines 25–32)
The speaker would do what others may have failed to accomplish.	(A)	(B)	(C)
The speaker would be productive and work without complaint.	(D)	(E)	(F)
The speaker would live simply and never give up.	(G)	(H)	(I)

Answer Key: C, E, G

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 37%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.4

Benchmark Description: Analyze structure, sound, imagery, and figurative language in poetry.

33. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Select **two** themes developed in Passage 2.

- Ⓐ Overcoming fears can be overwhelming.
- Ⓑ Growing old brings unhappiness and loss.
- Ⓒ People should lead full and useful lives when possible.
- Ⓓ Backing down from new opportunities may one day bring regret.
- Ⓔ The best advice comes from people who have experienced life to the fullest.

Part B

How does the poet develop the themes in Part A?

- Ⓐ by describing the simple life he wishes he could live
- Ⓑ by describing what he would do if he had his life to live over
- Ⓒ by describing decisions made by both young and old people
- Ⓓ by describing the kinds of battles he has had to fight regularly

Answer Key: C, D and B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 33%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.2

Benchmark Description: Analyze two or more themes and their development throughout a literary text.

Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

34. How are the perspectives of Maman-Nainaine in Passage 1 and the speaker in Passage 2 different?

- Ⓐ While Maman-Nainaine seeks solitude, the speaker seeks a life filled with different kinds of people.
- Ⓑ While Maman-Nainaine has accepted her place in society, the speaker feels lost in a confusing world.
- Ⓒ While Maman-Nainaine expects obedience from other people, the speaker wants to show his obedience to others.
- Ⓓ While Maman-Nainaine demonstrates satisfaction with her life, the speaker regrets not living a more courageous life.

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 61%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.1.3

Benchmark Description: Analyze how an author develops and individualizes the perspectives of different characters.

35. Which archetype does the speaker in Passage 2 praise?

- ☒ Ⓐ The Explorer, who is searching for a life of purpose
- ☐ Ⓑ The Artist, who endeavors to add beauty to the world
- ☐ Ⓒ The Innocent, who is inexperienced and seeks the safety of others
- ☐ Ⓓ The Caregiver, who provides support and offers help to those in need

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 67%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.3

Benchmark Description: Compare and contrast the use or discussion of archetypes in texts.

Grade 8 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

36. The archetype Death and Rebirth symbolizes the circle of life.

Complete the table to show how each passage illustrates The Death and Rebirth archetype.

	Passage 1	Passage 2	Both Passages
The passage shows the cyclical development of nature's bounty.	☒ A	☐ B	☐ C
The passage contrasts the outlooks and lives of people of different generations.	☐ D	☐ E	☒ F
The passage offers personal reflections and a desire to give rebirth to one's self.	☐ G	☒ H	☐ I

Answer Key: A, F, H

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 42%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.8.R.3.3

Benchmark Description: Compare and contrast the use or discussion of archetypes in texts.